India for one, foresaw the longevity early. Partly because we were pretty much insulated from the virus for about three weeks after it began to spread in other countries. The three weeks gave us a close insight into its dangerous multiplying ability. We also were very aware that considering the length and breadth of India, breaking the chain of the infection by making hosts unavailable was not possible. So, until there was strong evidenced treatment or a vaccine, right from the get-go, India had to be prepared to live with the virus.

Ever since we had only a handful of cases, the prime minister's economic team had been closely debating the strategy that would work best for our country. Emboldened by the prime minister's insistence on *jaan hai toh jahaan hai*, the goal was to save every Indian life possible, while being acutely aware of what world-renowned economists such as Joseph Stiglitz were preaching: 'The flatter we make the pandemic curve, the steeper the economic cost would be: that's the trade-off'.[23] Indian economists were also closely studying the failures of a moderate distancing approach, where social and economic activity would be allowed to continue only till the rate of infection doesn't explode, followed by disorderly de facto lockdowns.[24] At the time, many world-renowned economists including Nobel Laureates took the view that India's economic response should be one grand re-inflation package which would spend a lot of money trying to re-inflate the economy right upfront as early as April and May 2020.[25]

However, our prime minister, on the sound advice of his economic advisors, took the view, contrary to those opinions, that we were not in for a sprint, but rather a marathon which was going to take us through a great deal of uncertain terrain. So instead of using up all our ammunition right up front, India opted to adopt an adjusted approach: a modified version of the barbell strategy in modern economics.

Now what really is the modified barbell strategy? Let me explain. Imagine a barbell. It has two heavy components on either side, joined together by a small connecting line. Now, let's put it in context of the Indian economic scenario of the time. A modified barbell strategy would mean that the most risky outcomes would be insured against and feedback from restarting economic activity would determine each upcoming response. When the prime minister decided to lock down everything, it was an out-of-normal, once-in-a-century event. It was an extreme step, taken during a time of crisis when there were simply too many unknowns. Had we chosen